



WASHINGTON, DC CIVIC JOURNEY · 8TH GRADE · APRIL 14 TO 18, 2027

Student Journey Guide

Fourteen places, three days, one question. Carry this guide to every site, write in it at every stop, and bring it home with the evidence for your final response.

How does a democracy make decisions, preserve evidence, include voices and remember its past?

This guide belongs to _____

Group _____

My chaperone _____



Your Week

You carry one question all week. At each site you collect one piece of evidence in this guide. After the trip you use evidence from at least three sites to answer the question.



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Wed, April 14	Report to school 4:30 a.m.; bus leaves 5:00. Three rest stops and lunch on the way. Hotel about 1:35 p.m. Orientation seminar 4:30; dinner 5:30; room check 8:45; lights-out 9:30.
Thu, April 15	National Archives, U.S. Capitol, Library of Congress, and the Supreme Court from the steps. Dinner, then back to the hotel by 6:45 for the journal debrief.
Fri, April 16	National Museum of African American History and Culture, National Museum of American History, then the walk at dusk to four memorials. Bus at 8:45 sharp; hotel 9:30; lights-out 10:00.
Sat, April 17	Arlington National Cemetery, National Portrait Gallery, Lafayette Square and the White House. Dinner and the closing seminar at the hotel. Bus leaves 9:00 p.m.
Sun, April 18	Overnight bus with four rest stops. Back at school between 5:45 and 6:15 a.m. You are released only to an adult on your pickup list.

Wednesday: the journey east

Seven hours of driving, 372 miles, across Ohio, Pennsylvania and Maryland. Watch the land change. A national capital depends on the regions it connects.



● School ● Bus route ● Rest stops ● Hotel Mapbox · OpenStreetMap

Route note

Note how the land, the towns and the roads change between Lake Erie and the Potomac.

ON THE BUS

Your question for Washington

Write the one authentic question you are carrying to the capital.

How We Travel

Thirty students, six adults, one group of five for each of them. These are the rules that keep everyone together, and the card you carry in case they don't.



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The agreement you signed

- **Respect the places.** Follow the rules of every museum, memorial, cemetery, hotel and security checkpoint. Keep your voice down at places of loss and service.
- **Respect the group.** Stay with your chaperone and your buddy. Be on time. Take part in every head count. Never leave a site, the hotel or a rest stop on your own.
- **Respect the learning.** Complete your journal at each site. Listen to points of view different from yours. Put your phone away when asked.

Head counts and buddies

- Your chaperone counts you before and after every bus, at every entrance, before every move, at meals and at rest stops. Nobody moves until Ms. Carter closes the count.
- You have a buddy inside your group. Tell your chaperone before you use a restroom, and go with your buddy.
- Each morning Ms. Carter names the day's regroup point. If you are ever separated from your group, go there, or stay where you are and ask a uniformed staff member for help.

Phones

- On the bus and at the hotel until lights-out, yes. During programs, ceremonies and head counts, away.
- No photos of other students posted during the trip.

At the hotel

- Your assigned room only; no room changes. Stay on your floor after room check and keep the door closed.
- No pool, no fitness room, no exterior doors. Ever.
- Room check and medications at 8:45 p.m.; lights-out 9:30 (Friday 10:00). If you feel unwell at night, knock on your chaperone's door.

In your backpack every day

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ This guide and two pencils | ☐ Rain jacket or poncho |
| ☐ Refillable water bottle | ☐ Your trip card |
| ☐ A layer for the weather | ☐ Phone and charger, if you carry one |

Not into the museums: food, drink, pocketknives, aerosols. Lunch stays on the bus. Small backpacks only, because every building screens you at the door.

Your trip card

Cut it out, fill it in, keep it in your pocket all week.

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If you are separated: stay where you are. Ask a uniformed staff member for help. Call Emily Carter, trip leader: 216-555-0164 .		
Hotel: Holiday Inn Washington–College Park, 10000 Baltimore Avenue, College Park, MD 20740 · 301-345-6700		
My name _____	Group _____	
My chaperone _____	Chaperone's phone _____	

Thursday: Institutions and Founding Evidence



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The founding documents at the National Archives in the morning, then Capitol Hill: the Congress that works under them, and the library and court that stand beside it. **Institutions and power:** how law is made, recorded, interpreted and made available to the public.



Thursday, April 15 · numbered in visit order Mapbox · OpenStreetMap

WHERE	WHAT YOU WILL SEE	WHAT YOU DO
 1 National Archives Thursday 9:30 a.m.	The Declaration of Independence, the Constitution and the Bill of Rights, together in one round room.	Work with an Archives educator, then choose one founding document and one later record. Prompt 1.
 2 U.S. Capitol Thursday 1:00 p.m.	The Rotunda under the dome, Statuary Hall, and Exhibition Hall, which shows how a bill becomes law.	Map one path from a public concern to a law: who proposes, who debates, who votes, who signs. Prompt 2.
 3 Library of Congress Thursday 2:30 p.m.	The Great Hall's marble, mosaics and murals from 1897, and the Main Reading Room under its dome.	Read the building as a message about knowledge. Sketch one detail and write what it claims.
 4 Supreme Court Thursday 3:45 p.m.	The west steps, and the words above the entrance: Equal Justice Under Law.	A 20-minute lesson on the steps. Who decides what a law means? Write one sentence.

1 • Evidence

NATIONAL ARCHIVES

Choose one original record. What claim does it make, and what can it not tell us on its own?

2 • Institution

CAPITOL, LIBRARY OF CONGRESS, SUPREME COURT

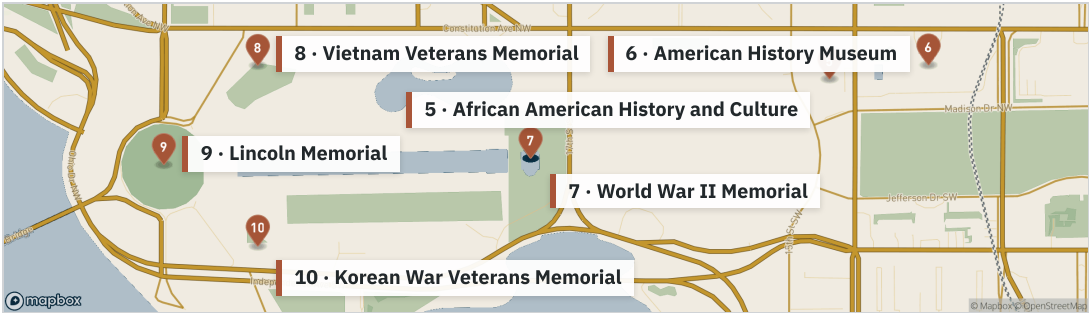
Where did you see power divided, checked or made visible? Name the evidence.

Friday: Voices, Rights and Public Memory

Two Smithsonian museums on the National Mall by day, then a walk at dusk through four memorials that end at the Lincoln Memorial. **Rights, voices and memory:** how objects, testimony and memorials shape what a nation remembers.



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Friday, April 16 · numbered in visit order Mapbox · OpenStreetMap

WHERE	WHAT YOU WILL SEE	WHAT YOU DO
 5 National Museum of African American History and Culture Friday 10:00 a.m.	The History Galleries three floors below ground, then the Culture Galleries above.	Follow one person's or one community's story across time. Prompt 3.
 6 National Museum of American History Friday 2:15 p.m.	The Star-Spangled Banner, and objects from everyday American life across three centuries.	Compare two objects that tell different stories about belonging. Prompt 4.
 7 World War II Memorial Friday 6:30 p.m.	Fifty-six pillars and two arches around a fountain, opened in 2004.	Start your design comparison: names, scale, materials, movement, silence. Prompt 5.
 8 Vietnam Veterans Memorial Friday evening	Maya Lin's wall of black granite, with more than 58,000 names in the order they were lost.	Walk the wall in silence. Find one name and record it.
 9 Lincoln Memorial Friday evening	Lincoln's statue looking down the Reflecting Pool; the Gettysburg Address on the wall.	Read the Gettysburg Address aloud with your group. Stand where the 1963 march ended.
 10 Korean War Veterans Memorial Friday evening	Nineteen steel figures walking through juniper toward the flag; the Wall of Remembrance.	Compare this memorial with the Vietnam wall. The bus leaves at 8:45 sharp.

3 • Voice

AFRICAN AMERICAN HISTORY AND CULTURE

Whose story changed or complicated what you thought you knew about U.S. history?

4 • Object

AMERICAN HISTORY

Which object carried the strongest story? Separate what you observed from what you inferred.

5 • Memory

THE MEMORIALS AT DUSK

How did the design of one memorial shape the way you moved, spoke or felt?

Saturday: Service, Leadership and Representation



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Across the Potomac to Arlington in the morning, then portraits of American leaders and the square in front of the White House before the closing seminar and the overnight ride home. **Service, leadership and representation:** how ritual, portraits and a public square say what a nation values.



Saturday, April 17 · numbered in visit order Mapbox · OpenStreetMap

WHERE	WHAT YOU WILL SEE	WHAT YOU DO
 11 Arlington National Cemetery Saturday 8:30 a.m.	The Kennedy gravesite, the Memorial Amphitheater, and the changing of the guard at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier.	Quiet voices, no food, no running. Prompt 6 is a private reflection; you keep it.
 12 National Portrait Gallery Saturday 1:00 p.m.	Every president in America's Presidents, inside the old Patent Office Building.	Choose one leader's portrait: pose, setting, symbols and the label. Prompt 7.
 13 Lafayette Square Saturday 3:15 p.m.	The park in front of the White House, where people have gathered and protested for two centuries.	Note who is there, what is protected, and what is open to view.
 14 White House Saturday afternoon	The north side of the White House from Pennsylvania Avenue.	Your last observation note before the closing seminar at the hotel.

6 • Service

ARLINGTON, PRIVATE

What did you notice about how people behave here, and what does that say about what is being honored? This one stays yours.

7 • Representation

PORTRAIT GALLERY

What does one portrait say about leadership? What is included, and what is left out?

Observation

LAFAYETTE SQUARE AND THE WHITE HOUSE

Who is present, what is protected, and what is open to view?

After the Trip

The closing seminar on Saturday evening, and the response you write when you are home. Both use the evidence in this guide.



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Final synthesis

CLOSING SEMINAR · SATURDAY 5:45 P.M.

Complete the claim with evidence from three sites: *A democracy stays accountable when...*

One idea that changed

One question that remains

Your final response, due Friday, April 30

Choose one: a 500-to-750-word argued response to the core question, *or* a three-panel civic exhibit pitch with captions and sources. Either way, use evidence from at least three different sites, name your sources, and include the idea that changed and the question that remains. Then the class chooses one Cleveland civic question to investigate with the same routines.

How your response is graded

The same four-point guide your teachers use

CRITERION	4 · STRONG	3 · SECURE	2 · DEVELOPING	1 · BEGINNING
Evidence	Specific, accurate evidence from three or more sites; sources clearly distinguished.	Relevant evidence from three sites.	General examples or unclear sources.	Few examples; claims unsupported.
Reasoning	Explains how the evidence supports and complicates the claim.	Connects evidence to the claim.	Connections are partial or repetitive.	Mostly summary; reasoning unclear.
Perspective	Compares viewpoints and names what is missing or omitted.	Includes more than one viewpoint.	Mentions difference without analysis.	One viewpoint presented as complete.
Participation	Prepared, respectful, curious and dependable at every site.	Consistently meets expectations.	Needs occasional reminders.	Conduct or participation limits learning.

What You Bring Home

Check each piece of evidence as you collect it. Together they are the material for your final response.



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| <ul style="list-style-type: none">☐ Route note from the journey east☐ Primary-source card (National Archives)☐ Institution diagram (U.S. Capitol)☐ Detail sketch and claim (Library of Congress)☐ One-sentence note (Supreme Court)☐ Voice-and-evidence pair (African American History and Culture) | <ul style="list-style-type: none">☐ Object comparison (American History)☐ Design comparison (the memorials)☐ Private reflection (Arlington), yours to keep☐ Portrait analysis (Portrait Gallery)☐ Observation note (Lafayette Square and the White House)☐ Exit claim (closing seminar) |
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Who to ask

- **Your chaperone** first, for everything.
- **Ms. Bennett** for the journal and the prompts.
- **Nurse Morgan** if you feel unwell, or for any medication.
- **Ms. Thompson** if something is hard, at a site or in your room.
- **Ms. Carter**, trip leader: 216-555-0164.

Notes

The journal is a record of observation and thinking, not a scavenger hunt. Short answers in the field are fine; longer thinking goes in the lines after each prompt or on the notes page. Take the quiet time after the galleries, the memorials and Arlington. Prepared by ETI360 for Horizon Ridge School of Cleveland from the 8th grade civics unit *Democracy in Place*.